2. If a data set was created using public funding, it should be released into the public domain in machine-readable form, while taking care to mask identifying information that would harm the privacy of private persons.

Summing up

A great deal of data in India is of low quality. This includes data that is produced by government agencies and the official statistical system. All official data cannot be trusted. We must take great interest in the methods and administrative difficulties, of each data source, before deciding to use it.

There are many coping mechanisms. Policy design can plan to discover prices through auctions, rather than assume that adequate information is available up front. There is a greater role for qualitative research, given the weaknesses of quantitative research.

Every policymaker must kick off long-range improvements in measurement. The most valuable thing, for the Indian policy process, is sustained measurement, and not one-off measurement. When a phenomenon is measured, again and again, we develop the long-term time series, and the observation of many units and many geographical locations. These are the most useful data sets of the country.

Government needs to release much more information in the public domain, particularly record-level anonymized micro data. What can be obtained through the RTI Act should be published. Data that is made using public money should always be released to the public. The private sector and the research community will do good things with data files, the only thing required of the government is to release the micro data.